Uncontrolled Subject Terms in the 653 Field

H 160

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A. Background

The assignment of uncontrolled subject words was originally intended as an expedient technique for providing minimal subject access to Minimal Level Cataloging (MLC) records. Staff performing minimal level cataloging use the title of the work as the primary source for words or phrases that are translated into English and add these to the 653 field. Staff performing minimal level cataloging do not analyze the book in depth, consult the authority files, attempt to assign these terms in any consistent or patterned manner, and do not agonize over the selection of terms. The principle followed is that some subject access is better than none, and that these uncontrolled terms should be assigned in as unstructured and unregulated a manner as possible.

In fully cataloged records, the 653 field serves a very different purpose. Primary subject access to these records is by the controlled vocabulary. The 653 field is used under exceptional

circumstances to provide supplementary subject access from natural language terms that are not included as headings or UF references in *Library of Congress Subject Headings* because of editorial policies, do not have precise English language equivalents, and do not duplicate headings in any of the other searchable fields.

The addition of the 653 field to fully cataloged records is strictly optional and should be done only on those rare occasions when the cataloger believes that the controlled vocabulary does not adequately convey the essence of the work in hand. It is not to be used in lieu of development work.

B. Recent revisions

2025-05: Updated to current template.

C. Assignment of 653 headings

C.1. Structure and placement of the field

Use only a single 653 field. Do not capitalize the first word of the field unless it is part of a proper name. Put each term or phrase in its own $a subfield. Use no punctuation at the end of each $a subfield.

Example:

```
245 10 $a Iparunk belföldi árainak kapcsolata a külkereskedelmi árakkal.
653 0# $a belföldi árak $a külkereskelmi árak
```

Input the 653 after all 600, 610, 611, 630, 650, and 651 subject headings but before any 655 genre term fields. Do not end the field with a mark of punctuation unless punctuation is part of the data.

C.2. Use of terms that are not headings or references

Use only terms that do not appear in the subject or name authority files as headings or UF references, or for which suitable English language equivalents do not exist. Generally, do not add geographic names, personal names, and corporate bodies to the 653 fields of fully cataloged records.

Example:

```
245 14 $a The unification of Italy.
651 #0 $a Italy $x History $y 1849-1870.

[Risorgimento should not be added as a 653, since this appears in
the subject authority file as a UF under the heading *Italy—History—
1849-1870*.]
```

C.3. Non-duplication of terms

Do not add a term to the 653 field that duplicates a term appearing in another searchable field.

C.4. Foreign terms

Convert foreign terms for which there is no English equivalent to a form under which the user is most likely to search (for example, uninflected form, stem form, nominative case).

Example:

```
245 10 $a Edo jidai bugyōshoku jiten.
653 0# $a bugyō
```

C.5. Use of natural word order

Record phrases in natural word order.

C.6. Order of terms

When adding several words or phrases to a bibliographic record, do not attempt to assign them in order of relative importance.

C.7. Maximum number of terms

Assign a maximum of 3 words or phrases.

C.8. Previously verified records

Do not add a 653 field to previously verified records.

C.9. Changing previously assigned 653 fields

Do not alter previously assigned 653 fields.

C.10. Deleting 653 fields

Delete a 653 field only when it is discovered that a new heading duplicates a 653 field in a bibliographic record.

Revision history

2025-05: Updated to current template.